

A peek inside

Whale bones are more porous than our bones and contain a lot of oil. Oil floats in water, so the huge quantities inside a whale help its buoyancy, or ability to float, in water.

Bone facts

- Whale bones are often displayed in museums to help people see what they look like and how big they are.
- Whale bones don't carry the weight of the whale; the water does that.
- The oil makes whale bones smell as they dry out.

Hidden protection

Just like a human skeleton, a whale's skeleton has a backbone and a long, slender rib cage that protects the delicate internal organs.

Orca skeleton

Is it a dog?

A seal's skeleton is more like a dog's than a whale's. It even has hind limb bones in its tail flipper.

Elephant seal skeleton

A whale has a shoulder blade, or scapula.

Human shoulder blade

A ball-and-socket joint allows all-around movement.

Strong flippers

The bones in a whale's flipper are short and strong for efficient steering.

Finger bones

A whale has finger bones, just like us.

Finger bones

Human bones

Compare a whale's flipper with a human's arm bones. Both have the same bones, but they are shaped differently.